



STEPPE

Funder Eligibility & Cost-Mapping

Reference

REDMOND • CENTRAL OREGON • EST. 2026

v3 • 2026-07-09

A member-governed Oregon public benefit nonprofit.

Internal note • 2026-07-09. Working draft, converted from Word to Markdown and rebranded to Steppe. Facts to rely on: the fiscal sponsor is **Ignite Empowerment Foundation**, a Central Oregon 501(c)(3) (EIN 99-3872440), with the sponsorship agreement pending signature. Director Brandon Weimer is the spouse of the foundation's founder, so Steppe and the foundation handle their arrangement as a disclosed related party (see docs/governance/). Dues are **\$4 a month**. The founding board is Chism, Cobb, and Weimer, with a fourth independent director planned. Before sending this to a funder, apply the open items in docs/funding/funder-pack-corrections-v1.md (grant-ask sizing, board-independence wording, and the 2026 pipeline dates).

Steppe

a high desert civic commons

Funder Eligibility & Cost-Mapping Reference

Companion to the Business Plan funding model • Eligibility, cost-mapping & growth-stage funding, base dues \$4/mo • v3 • June 14, 2026

How to read this. The Business Plan reserves dues for core operations and assigns foundation grants to capacity and expansion only. This reference puts the eligible-cost detail beneath that rule: for each named funder, what it will and won't pay for, then a map from Steppe's early budget lines to the funder best suited to each. All three primary funders accept applications from fiscally-sponsored organizations — the route Steppe will use through its Model C sponsor until its own determination arrives. Figures and windows below should be reconfirmed on each funder's page before applying.

1 --- Funder Profiles

Oregon Community Foundation --- Community Grants

Statewide community funder; flexible support; weights community input heavily. Two cycles a year.

Amount Up to \$40,000.

Cycle Fall 2026 window is open now: May 26 – June 23, 2026 (5 p.m. PT). New applicants must set up a / MyOCF profile first (cutoff was June 18 for this cycle). A spring cycle also runs annually.

**dead-
line**

Eligibility 501(c)(3), Tribal, or government entities in Oregon, or based in / primarily serving Oregon; all activities & must occur in Oregon. Fiscally-sponsored orgs apply under their OWN org record and submit a sponsorship agreement signed by both parties and dated within the past year. Especially competitive: **spon-** small rural orgs (population ≤35,000; under \$250k operating expenses) and culturally specific **sor** organizations.

Funds New or expanding programs and projects; capacity building; small capital under \$500k (equipment, **(eli-** ADA remodels, outreach vehicles); flexible operating support.

**gi-
ble)**

Excludes individuals; activities outside Oregon; a partial phase of a capital project whose full cost exceeds \$500k.

Best Spanish localization and accessibility (equity); community fieldwork; launch programming; capacity **fit for** building (board/systems); small capital such as outreach devices.

Steppe

Verify oregoncf.org → Community Grants Program Guidelines.

Roundhouse Foundation --- Sisters (closest geographic fit)

Rural Central Oregon; Sisters is a priority; relationship-first and collaborative. Focus areas: Arts & Culture, Environmental Stewardship, Social Services, Education.

Programs & amounts	Small Grants \$500–\$2,500 (rolling, Jan–Nov, reviewed monthly) — grassroots/low-budget work, recommended as the “get to know each other” first ask. Open Call \$2,501–\$30,000 (median ~\$20,000; biannual: spring Jan–Mar, fall Jun–Aug; 12–18-month proposals). Technical Assistance & Professional Development up to \$5,000.
Eligibility & sponsor	501(c)(3), Tribal, or government entities serving rural Oregon. Fiscally-sponsored orgs ARE eligible but must be actively in pursuit of 501(c)(3) status. One proposal per calendar year; no open grants and none received in the past 12 months.
Funds (eligible)	Program/project work; capacity (the TA grant); and — notably — program-aligned infrastructure or equipment, which their guidelines list as including software, through the Open Call.
Excludes	Capital facility development through Open Call (except program-aligned equipment); individuals and scholarships; for-profits; faith-based and political groups; endowments; commitments beyond four years; organizations in active litigation or intense public scrutiny.
Best fit for Steppe	Small Grant for a discrete fieldwork series or the Sisters pilot; Open Call for launch programming plus program-aligned app/software work; TA grant for board and systems capacity.
Verify	roundhousefoundation.org → How to Apply / Eligibility.

The Ford Family Foundation --- Good Neighbor Grants

Rural Oregon and Siskiyou County, CA. Priorities: Family, Education, Community (community building, economic development, strengthening organizational capacity).

Amount	Up to \$25,000. Rolling — no fixed deadline; decisions in roughly six to ten weeks. Separate Technical Assistance grants also available.
Eligibility & match	Rural communities; must show community support (“the community at the table”) and a clear sustainability plan. Key constraint: 25% of the budget committed before applying (in-kind can count, but the strongest requests have other cash at the table).
Funds (eligible)	Both program and capital. Up to 1/3 may be requested for programs/operations and up to 50% for capital. Explicitly fundable: capacity-building consultants (strategic planning, board development, leadership transitions, fundraising strategy, fiscal systems); staff training; facility updates including ADA accessibility and technology; emergency repairs.
Best fit for Steppe	Fieldwork and launch programming; and especially capacity-building for a brand-new org — board development, fiscal systems, fundraising strategy — plus accessibility/technology. Up to a third can go to operations.
Watch	The 25% match is the gating requirement — line up other committed or in-kind funds first. Verify at tfff.org → Open Grants.

The Bend Foundation --- Bend-area (private foundation)

Long-standing local Bend-area funder. Public eligibility detail is thin — confirm specifics directly before relying on this.

Cycles (2026)	Two windows: Jan 5 – Mar 5 (decision Apr 30) and May 18 – July 17, 2026 (decision Aug 31; grants by Sept 30). The summer window is open now. (Note: my earlier “~November” was wrong — corrected here.)
Funds / eligibility	Bend-area community benefit. Specific eligible/excluded costs are not well documented publicly — confirm directly at bendfoundation.org .

Best fit for Steppe	A Bend-specific slice — library programming, the Bend launch.
Also consider	Separately, the City of Bend Community Sponsorship & Grant Program (municipal; deadlines Mar 31 and Sept 30) funds community programs/events with a clear public purpose and accepts fiscally-sponsored applicants — a small additional source for launch events.

2 --- Mapping Steppe's Early Costs to Funders

Early cost line	Best-fit funder(s)	Note
Legal & formation (Articles, DOJ, Form 1023, trademark)	Mostly dues / donations; Ford Family capacity (fiscal systems, board development) touches org-building	Filing fees themselves are rarely grant-funded
Fiscal sponsor fee (5-15%)	Build into each grant budget as allowable admin	Not a standalone ask; nets off routed grants
App — accessibility pass	OCF (capacity/equity); Ford Family (ADA + technology); Roundhouse Open Call (program-aligned software)	Frame as access/equity, not “development”
App — Spanish localization & review	OCF (culturally-specific/equity); Roundhouse (Social Services); Ford Family (Community)	Strong equity framing
Community fieldwork (travel, materials, stipends)	Roundhouse Small Grant / Open Call; OCF (program); Ford Family (community building)	Roundhouse Small Grant is the cleanest first ask
Beta & launch programming	OCF (new/expanding program); Roundhouse Open Call; Ford Family; Bend Foundation (Bend slice)	OCF and Open Call carry the largest amounts
Capacity building (board, fiscal systems, fundraising)	Ford Family (explicit); Roundhouse TA grant (≤\$5k); OCF (capacity building)	Ford Family is best-tailored here
Moderation honoraria	Program budget within OCF / Roundhouse / Ford Family asks	Frame as program staffing/stipends, not “funds to individuals”
Outreach devices / equipment	OCF small capital; Roundhouse program-aligned equipment	Tie equipment to a named program
ED salary & core operations	Dues + unrestricted donations (per BP funding model)	Ford Family allows up to 1/3 to operations within a project — minor only

3 --- Funding by Growth Stage

Dues scale with membership and anchor core operations; grants fund capacity and expansion at each stage; founder pay is multi-source and rises only with scale. This reproduces and corrects the earlier stage model — which used the now-retired PBC-to-501(c)(3) conversion framing — and aligns it with the fiscal-sponsor bridge and the funders above. The base membership price is locked at \$4/month (billed annually or via ACH); a hardship waiver preserves access and a voluntary contribution layer sits above it.

Stage & scale	Dues & founder pay	What grants & other explicitly fund	Vote / gate
---------------	--------------------	-------------------------------------	-------------

Stage 0 — Pre-launch / formation • Now-Dec 2026 • 0 members	No dues yet. Founder \$0 (side-project; academic salary covers him).	Via the Model C fiscal sponsor: community fieldwork; Spanish localization & accessibility; closed-beta / pilot costs. Roundhouse Small Grant + Ford Family lead. Legal & formation paid from dues-to-come and donations, not grants.	Legal incorporation; closed-beta validation.
Stage 1 — Launch & root in Redmond • Yr 1 • →~200 members (~\$9.6K/yr)	Dues cover hosting + basic tools. Founder volunteer / minimal.	Launch programming; continued localization & accessibility; first transparency report; beta internship (1-2 students). Roundhouse, Ford Family, OCF Fall, Bend Foundation (Bend slice). Year-end donations + Community Fund begin.	200 members; governance operational and stable.
Stage 2 — Full Central Oregon coverage • Yr 1-2 • →~500 members (~\$24K/yr)	Dues cover ops + part-time help + a modest founder stipend (\$15-25k), topped by grant overhead (10-15%).	Additional-town fieldwork (La Pine, Sisters, Prineville, Madras); capacity building (board development, fiscal systems — Ford Family / Roundhouse TA); new community features. OCF expanding-program, Roundhouse Open Call, Ford Family. IRS determination likely lands → sponsor spin-out; grants convert to direct.	Community vote to expand; 500 members; town qualification.
Stage 3 — Sustainable + program arm • Yr 2-3 • →~1,000 members (~\$48K/yr)	Dues now cover ops + a sustainable salary (~\$37k available toward salary at 1,000 members; the \$95k ceiling becomes dues-fundable near ~2,300 members). The LLC winds down at full-time.	Steppe Connect program arm — rural connectivity + the Tribal Digital Sovereignty Program — grant-funded, never dues. Government grants become eligible (2028+). Foundation + government program grants.	Founder-protection period running; multi-town governance activates.
Stage 4 — Replication & long horizon • 2028+ • →3,500+ members	Dues fully anchor (~\$168k/yr at 3,500 members); founder pay stable at the ceiling, the remainder surplus to the Community Fund.	Government grants (radically transparent); the Warm Springs partnership (co-led, separately funded, never the operating budget); replication support (earned revenue).	Vote per expansion; founder-protection sunsets at 3,500 sustained four quarters.

Founder-pay ladder (unchanged): \$0 while a side-project → \$15-25k during significant part-time involvement → up to the \$95k full-time ceiling (3% COLA cap, set below the academic salary). Drawn first from dues, then grant overhead (10-15%), then earned revenue; donations only on surplus. At the locked \$4 base, dues alone fund the full \$95k ceiling near ~2,300 members (~6.5% of Redmond), so the grant-overhead and earned-revenue layers are a bridge below that scale, not a permanent dependence.

Membership benchmarks: 200 ≈ 0.5% of Redmond (near-term trust milestone); 500 ≈ 1.3% (a 12-18-month target); 1,000 members yields ~\$48k/yr in dues; the \$95k ceiling is dues-fundable near ~2,300 members (~6.5% of Redmond); 3,500 sustained four quarters is the founder-protection sunset (~\$168k/yr in dues, surplus to the Community Fund).

4 --- Sequencing & Guardrails

The gating item is the signed fiscal-sponsorship agreement, not the calendar.

Three windows are open now — OCF Fall (closes June 23), Bend Foundation summer (closes July 17), and the Roundhouse fall Open Call (Jun–Aug). But each effectively requires the fiscal-sponsor agreement already in hand (OCF wants it signed within the past year; Roundhouse requires active pursuit of 501(c)(3) status). If the Ignite Empowerment Foundation agreement is not signed within days, the June 23 OCF deadline is too tight — and a thin application rushed without fieldwork evidence is worse than waiting for the next cycle.

Recommended near-term path: lead with the two rolling, deadline-free options that also fit Steppe’s actual readiness — the Roundhouse Small Grant (monthly review, welcomes fiscally-sponsored orgs in pursuit of status, and is explicitly the “get to know each other” entry) and the Ford Family Good Neighbor grant (rolling, once the 25% match is lined up). Use those to build a track record and relationships, then target the OCF Fall cycle and the Roundhouse fall Open Call in the next round, once the sponsor agreement and fieldwork evidence are both in hand.

Guardrails

- Keep any single grant under 30% of total revenue — size and stagger asks accordingly.
- Each grant is restricted: track every award against its allowed budget lines, and net the sponsor’s 5–15% fee out of the usable total.
- Line up Ford Family’s 25% match (cash or in-kind) before applying there.
- Frame app work as accessibility, equity, and community access for most funders; Roundhouse is the one that will fund “program-aligned software” by that name.
- Dues fund core operations and the ED salary — never a grant. This keeps Steppe inside both its funding model and its anti-dependency commitments.

Confirm before applying. Amounts, windows, and eligible-cost lists change by cycle. Reconfirm each on the funder’s own page — especially the Bend Foundation, whose public guidelines are limited. This reference is a companion to, not a replacement for, the Business Plan funding model.